conversation in an extraordinary entry in his diary:

> I have told the Sec. for War, Mr Stimson, to use it so that military objectives and soldiers and sailors are the target and not women and children. Even if the Japs are savages, ruthless, merciless and fanatic, we as the leader of the world for the common welfare cannot drop this terrible bomb on the old Capital or the new. He & I are in accord. The target will be a purely military one and we will issue a warning statement asking the Japs to surrender and save lives. I'm sure they will not do that, but we will have given them the chance.[41]

How could Truman see cities as 'purely military' targets? In Hiroshima there were, admittedly, 43,000 Japanese soldiers, but there were also some 300,000 civilians.[42] Truman's words reflected his private thoughts, so were not a public rationalisation of his decision. In hindsight, they may seem disingenuous or indeed self-delusional (though they were written behind the veil of ignorance before the effects of the bombs were known). Alex Wallerstein proffers the more straightforward and eminently plausible explanation that Truman simply did not understand that the targets were cities with large civilian populations, reflecting the fact that he was 'out of his league' in the early stages of his presidency.[43]

Bad weather

Stimson discussed the targeting of the bombs with Truman on the 22 and 24 July 1945. When Kyoto was removed from the target list, another Japanese city was added. Stimson cabled his assistant from Potsdam, that with the exclusion of Kyoto, the targets were Hiroshima, Kokura and Niigata 'in order of choice here'. [44] Nagasaki was added later.

Hiroshima was bombed on 6 August 1945, using a uranium bomb (nicknamed 'Little Boy'). On 9 August 1945, a B-29 Superfortress took off from Tinian Air base in the Mariana islands to attack the city of Kokura.[45] *Bockscar,* captained by Major Charles W. Sweeney, carried a plutonium